Dhruv and exam controller Aarti Wasnik. The registration of cases was followed up with searches at the premises of Sonwane, Dhruv and Congress leader Rajendra Shukla, among others.

Sonwane's tenure coincided with the selection of five of his relatives—his son as deputy collector, daughter-in-law in another position, nephew as deputy superintendent of police (DSP), and nieces as a labour officer and a district excise officer. Dhruv's sons were selected as an assistant conservator of forests

SEVERAL SUCCESSFUL CGPSC CANDIDATES ARE RELATIVES OF TOP CGPSC OFFICIALS AND POLITICIANS

(ACF) and a DSP. Besides Shukla, another Congress leader, Sudhir Katiyar, is also reportedly being probed. The selection of Katiyar's daughter and son-in-law, as well as Shukla's daughter, is under scrutiny, as is that of the wards of another former IAS officer, Amrit Xalxo, and a DIG-rank IPS officer.

Interestingly, in June 2023, just weeks after the scandal broke, the CGPSC issued a tender to destroy answer sheets, including those from the years when the alleged beneficiaries were selected. However, the tender was withdrawn following protests.

While the CBI remains tight-lipped about the investigation, those associated with the complaints point to the role of coaching centres in the scandal. They claim that in the multiple-choice tests, certain questions may have been leaked to select aspirants, and for essay-type answers, specialised coaching may have been provided at secret locations. "When Bhupesh Baghel was chief minister, Sonwane was in his secretariat. What was the reason for appointing him chairman of the PSC? There have been misdeeds before 2020-22 too, which should be covered in the investigation," says Gouri Shanker Shrivas, BJP leader and whistleblower in the scandal. Meanwhile, the Chhattisgarh High Court has ordered that the suspected candidates not be allowed to join service.

Deputy collectors, DSPs and ACFs are state civil servants but are eligible for induction into the elite IAS, IPS and Indian Forest Service (IFS) after completion of certain criteria, including number of years in service. In other words, several deputy collectors, DSPs and ACFs end up becoming IAS, IPS and IFS officers after some years in the state service.

"The CBI inquiry is part of the BJP's propaganda, and Congress leaders are not involved in any scandal. Children of Congress leaders can also take exams and clear them on their own merit. Regarding the selection of the former chairman's relatives, the party welcomes the CBI inquiry and wants the agency to find out the truth," says Congress spokesperson Sushil Anand Shukla.

Meanwhile, civil services aspirants in Chhattisgarh continue to feel dejected. "Even after so many months, not a single official from the PSC has been held accountable. I took the PSC civil services exam six times and wrote the mains exam three times. However, I've given up on writing the exam due to doubts about the selection process. Now, I'm working in the real estate sector," says Keshav Sahu, a Raipur-based aspirant. It's now up to the CBI to overturn the disillusionment of Sahu and many others like him. ■



By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

Almost a century after its disbandment and a touch-and-go attempt at its revival, the mounted unit of the Mumbai Police is expected to make a comeback in a new avatar later this year. In July, the Maharashtra government's home department sanctioned over Rs 38 crore to procure horses and set up a stable and other facilities at Marol in the suburb. The proposal to raise the unit, comprising 30 horses, was approved by the state cabinet on July 5.

"After the government's decision, we are working to improve the infrastructure, train manpower and induct new horses to start the mounted police unit of the Mumbai Police," S. Jay Kumar, joint commissioner of police (administration), tells INDIA TODAY. A senior police officer says the horses will be used for crowd regulation and patrolling on beaches and promenades such as Girgaum Chowpatty, Juhu and Madh. "Policemen have the advantage of height while patrolling on horseback. Normally, we patrol at a height of over five feet while on foot. When astride a horse, we are at an even greater height and can see the entire crowd. The rider can also control the speed of his mount," he explains. Using horses will also magnify the presence of the police at these locations and help control anti-social elements or a mob.